

Word family: **dense / denser / densest / densely / density**

Base word: dense

Comparative: denser

Superlative: densest

Related forms: densely, density

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / related adverb and noun forms (相關副詞及名詞)

Your sentence:

> “By contrast, I imagine Sapiens will be **denser**, sharper, and more intellectually stimulating.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **denser** means **containing a lot of information, ideas, or meaning in a relatively small amount of text, so it may require more concentration to understand**.

繁體中文： **內容密集的；資訊量大、概念多，因此讀起來較需要專注的**

中文翻譯：

> “I imagine Sapiens will be **denser**...”

「我想《人類大歷史》的內容會更**密集 / 厚重**.....」

Here:

dense writing = 在不算很長的篇幅內包含很多資訊、概念或論證，需要較仔細閱讀

1. **dense = closely packed together (物理密集) — 稠密的；密集的**

Meaning: Containing many things packed closely together in a small space.

Practice 1

> “They walked through a **dense** forest.”

「他們穿過一片**茂密的**森林。」

Practice 2

> “The city has a **dense** network of narrow streets.”

「這座城市有一個非常**密集的**狹窄街道網絡。」

****dense = 很多物體集中在較小空間內，彼此距離很近****

Common:

- * dense forest
- * dense vegetation
- * dense crowd
- * dense network

This is the core physical sense.

2. ****dense = containing a lot of information/ideas (文字 / 內容) — 內容密集的；難消化的****

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 3 — Original

> “I imagine the book will be ****denser**** than the novels I usually read.”

「我想這本書會比我平時讀的小說****內容更密集****。」

Practice 4

> “The article is short but extremely ****dense****.”

「這篇文章雖然短，但內容非常****密集****。」

Practice 5

> “The chapter is ****dense**** with historical detail.”

「這一章充滿大量歷史細節，內容十分****密集****。」

****dense = 在有限篇幅中集中大量資訊、概念、細節或論證，因此理解起來較費力****

Common:

- * dense text
- * dense prose
- * dense argument
- * dense with information

This is a major figurative sense derived from physical packing.

3. **dense** = difficult to understand because complex (難懂) — 晦澀的；難理解的

Dense can describe language, theory, writing, or explanations that are difficult to follow because they are complex or heavily packed.

Practice 6

> “The theory is quite **dense**.”

「這套理論相當**晦澀難懂**。」

Practice 7

> “His explanation was too **dense** for beginners.”

「他的解釋對初學者來說太**難理解**。」

dense = 因內容複雜、壓縮或概念太多而難以理解的

For strict counting, I would merge this with Meaning 2 rather than create a separate core sense.

4. **dense** = having high physical density (科學) — 密度高的

In science, **dense** means having a large amount of mass in a given volume.

Practice 8

> “Lead is denser than aluminium.”

「鉛的**密度**比鋁高。」

Practice 9

> “The material is extremely **dense**.”

「這種材料的**密度很高**。」

dense = 單位體積內含有較多質量的；密度高的

This is a major technical/scientific sense.

5. **dense** = thick / difficult to see through (霧 / 煙 / 液體) — 濃密的 ; 濃厚的

Dense can describe fog, smoke, cloud, etc. when it is thick and blocks visibility.

Practice 10

> “The road disappeared into **dense** fog.”

「道路消失在**濃霧**之中。」

Practice 11

> “The room filled with **dense** smoke.”

「房間裡充滿**濃煙**。」

dense = 物質濃厚、厚重，以致難以看穿或穿過

This is still closely connected to physical compactness.

6. **dense** = stupid / slow to understand (非正式) — 遲鈍的 ; 笨的

In informal British and other varieties of English, calling a person **dense** can mean they are slow to understand something.

Practice 12

> “Are you being **dense** on purpose?”

「你是故意裝**遲鈍** / 不明白嗎？」

Practice 13

> “I felt a bit **dense** when I finally understood the joke.”

「我最後才聽懂那個笑話時，覺得自己有點**遲鈍**。」

dense = 理解力很慢、很難明白明顯事情的

This is a distinct informal sense and can sound insulting.

Related form: ****densely****

****Densely**** means in a closely packed or highly concentrated way.

Practice 14

> “The region is ****densely**** populated.”

「這個地區人口****稠密****。」

Practice 15

> “The article is ****densely**** written.”

「這篇文章寫得非常****密集 / 濃縮****。」

****densely = 以高密度、集中或內容壓縮的方式****

Related form: ****density****

****Density**** means the degree of compactness or concentration.

Practice 16

> “Population ****density**** is very high in the city.”

「這座城市的人口****密度****很高。」

Practice 17

> “The scientist measured the ****density**** of the liquid.”

「科學家測量了液體的****密度****。」

Practice 18

> “The ****density**** of information made the chapter difficult to read.”

「資訊的****密集程度****令這一章較難閱讀。」

****density = 密度；集中程度；單位空間中事物的含量****

Important distinction: **dense vs heavy**

In writing:

dense

emphasizes:

- * lots of information
- * ideas packed closely
- * concentration required

heavy

can mean:

- * serious
- * emotionally weighty
- * intellectually demanding

So:

- > dense book
- > heavy book

can overlap, but **dense** specifically suggests **content packed tightly**.

Important distinction: **dense vs difficult**

difficult

is broad: hard to understand or do.

dense

often explains *why* something is difficult:

- > because there is a lot packed into it.

A text can be difficult without being dense.

Important distinction: ****dense vs complex****

****complex****

means having many interconnected parts or ideas.

****dense****

means those ideas/details are packed closely together.

Something can be complex but explained clearly and therefore not dense.

Important distinction: ****dense vs thick****

For fog/smoke/vegetation:

****thick****

means abundant or hard to see through.

****dense****

emphasizes concentration and closeness.

> thick fog

> dense fog

Both are natural.

For scientific density, however:

> dense material

is much more precise than:

> thick material

Important distinction: ****dense vs crowded****

****crowded****

means many people/things are present and there is little space.

****dense****

describes concentration more neutrally.

- > crowded room
- > dense population

Different typical collocations.

Important distinction: ****dense vs compact****

****compact****

means tightly arranged in a small space, often deliberately or efficiently.

****dense****

means highly concentrated, whether or not deliberately arranged.

- > compact design
- > dense forest

Countability note

****Dense**** is an adjective, so countability does not apply directly.

****Density**** can be:

countable in technical contexts

- > different densities

uncountable/abstract

- > population density
- > information density

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **dense**
* **denser**
* **densest**
* **densely**
* **density**

The main semantic branches are:

* physical closeness/concentration
* informational concentration
* scientific mass-per-volume density
* informal mental slowness

The forest/fog/smoke/population uses all share the broad idea of **a high concentration in limited space**, so they should not be split merely because the substance changes.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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dense — physically packed	很多物體集中在較小空間內，彼此距離很近；稠密的
dense — information/writing	在有限篇幅中集中大量資訊、概念或論證，讀起來較費力
dense — scientific	單位體積內含有較多質量的；密度高的
dense — fog/smoke	濃厚、集中，以致難以看穿的；屬於 physical concentration 義
dense — person, informal	理解力慢、很難明白明顯事情的；遲鈍的
densely	以高密度、密集或濃縮方式
density	密度；集中程度

For your original sentence

> “By contrast, I imagine Sapiens will be **denser**, sharper, and more intellectually stimulating.”

The exact meaning is:

denser = 書中的資訊、概念和論證更集中、更豐富，因此需要更仔細、更專注地閱讀

So:

> **a denser book**

= **一本內容更密集、更厚重、更需要消化的書**

It does **not** simply mean “longer” or “more difficult.” A short book can also be very dense if it contains a lot of ideas in little space.

For your database, I would count **4** genuinely useful core meanings for **dense**:

1. **physically closely packed / concentrated**
2. **information or ideas packed tightly; intellectually demanding**
3. **scientifically high in mass per unit volume**
4. **informal: slow to understand / stupid**

I would merge **dense fog, dense forest, dense population** into #1, and merge “difficult-to-read prose” into #2 rather than inflate the core count.